📋 COM142 · UNIVERSITY OF BOTSWANA ONLINE MCQ TEST · 30%

Complete Study Interface — All Modules

Fully integrated from all lecture slides + APA citation module. Every section is structured around what the **scenario-based MCQ test** will ask: given a situation, identify the correct stage, report type, paragraph type, citation format, or writing feature.

📝 Module 1 · Writing Process

Academic writing, three stages, prewriting, drafting, post-writing, integrity, source integration.

🔬 Module 2 · Scientific Style

Language features, coherence, nominalisation, paragraph types, hedging, graphics.

📄 Module 3 · Reports

All report types — formal/informal, lab, fieldwork, accident, trip, trouble reports.

📚 Module 4 · APA Citations

APA 7th ed. in-text and reference list formats, all source types, scenario-based citation practice.

⚠️ **MCQ Test Strategy:** For every scenario, ask yourself **(1) What is the person doing?** and **(2) What type of text are they producing?** These two questions eliminate wrong answers and guide you to the correct one almost every time.

📝 MODULE 1 DR. RICHMOND NGULA

Introduction to Academic Writing

Academic writing is both a **process and a product**. The process is a systemic series of actions designed to achieve a well-written piece. The product is the final essay or report. COM142 trains you in both.

WHAT IS ACADEMIC WRITING?

Academic writing refers to written texts produced by scholars and students in an academic context. It is an important and complex skill that has **rhetorical, linguistic, and disciplinary elements**. There is a specific way to write in proper academic style that must be consciously learned.

📐 Elaboration

Ideas fully developed with evidence, examples, explanation. Unsupported claims are unacceptable.

🗂️ Organisation

Logical, predictable structure — introduction, development, conclusion. One idea per paragraph.

🎭 Style

Formal, no contractions/slang, third-person preferred. Objective, impersonal language throughout.

⚙️ Mechanics

Correct grammar, spelling, punctuation, and proper referencing. Errors undermine credibility.

📌 THREE ORIENTATIONS OF ACADEMIC WRITING

Writer-oriented: focuses on the processes writers use. **Reader-oriented:** emphasises the audience and persuasion. **Text-oriented:** focuses on how texts should be structured.

💡 PURPOSES OF ACADEMIC WRITING

- **Produce new knowledge** for the academic community (e.g., research articles)
- **Disseminate existing knowledge** for learners (e.g., undergraduate essays, textbooks)

Types of student academic writing:

- Essays (exposition, reflection, argumentation)
- Mini research reports (lab/field reports)
- Article/literature reviews
- Literature reviews on a topic
- Postgraduate theses/dissertations

🪤 MCQ TRAP

If a student uses slang, writes "I think," or makes unsupported claims — the answer targets a **missing feature of academic writing style**.

SCIENTISTS AS COMMUNICATORS

🔭 Communication = Core Scientific Skill

Communication skills are **as important as scientific knowledge** for the scientist. Scientists follow systematic and replicable procedures and report

⚠️ What "Science" Really Means

Every discipline is a "science." There is a difference between writing **as a scientist** (systematic, evidenced, replicable) and writing as someone in the new knowledge — primarily in writing.

pure/applied sciences only.

📌 SCIENTIFIC WRITING QUALITY: THREE CORE REQUIREMENTS

Academic writing is most effective when it is: **(1) Clear and easy to read — (2) Concise and precise — (3) Neutral or formal in style.** Clarity, readability, conciseness, and precision are especially critical in science because science must build trust on issues that impact society.

THE THREE-STAGE WRITING PROCESS

STAGE 1	→	STAGE 2	→	STAGE 3
Prewriting		**Writing / Drafting**		**Post-Writing**
Planning & Gathering		Structuring & Composing		Revise · Edit · Proofread

🔴 MOST TESTED MODULE 1 CONCEPT

The test will give a scenario ("a student is creating a mind map / fixing spelling errors / moving paragraphs around") and ask which stage or sub-activity it belongs to. Know every activity for every stage cold.

STAGE 1 · PREWRITING

Everything that happens **before the first draft**. Goal: clarify thinking, gather material, plan structure.

🎯 Choose & Narrow Topic

Select a topic and narrow its scope to be manageable. Broad topics cannot be covered effectively in a single essay or report.

👥 Determine Audience

Identify **who will read** the text. Adjust vocabulary, tone, and complexity. Expert readers ≠ non-specialists ≠ technical readers.

🎯 Determine Purpose

Identify why you are writing — to **inform, argue, describe, analyse, or persuade**. Purpose shapes every decision that follows.

🧠 Generate Ideas (Brainstorm)

Use **mind maps** (visual webs from a central concept) or **concept maps** (showing relationships between ideas) to generate content rapidly.

🔍 Gather Supporting Information

Use **advanced search** — keywords, synonyms, Boolean operators (AND/OR/NOT), database filters — to find credible academic sources.

📋 Structure / Outline

Create a **hierarchical plan** of main points and sub-points in logical order before drafting begins.

STAGE 2 · WRITING (FIRST DRAFT)

Turn the outline into a full draft. Focus on **structure, content, and coherence**. Also includes getting and acting on feedback.

SECTION	PURPOSE & REQUIRED FEATURES
🔵 **Introductory Paragraph**	**Opening/general background** that arrests the reader's interest. States the **purpose and scope** of the essay — tells the reader clearly what parts of the topic will be covered.
🟣 **Body Paragraphs**	Each paragraph develops **one main idea/issue**. Structure: **topic sentence → concrete supporting sentences (main and minor) → concluding sentence**.
🟢 **Concluding Paragraph**	Restates thesis, summarises key points, provides closure. **Does NOT introduce new information.** May include implications or recommendations.

🪤 MCQ TRAP

A question may describe a student introducing a new argument in the conclusion. This is always a **structural error**. Conclusions must only restate/synthesise.

STAGE 3 · POST-WRITING

🔁 Revision

Macro-level. Restructure paragraphs, rewrite arguments, move sections, improve coherence. Works at **content and organisation level**.

✏️ Editing

Sentence-level. Spelling, grammar, punctuation, sentence structure, cohesive elements, word choice, rhetorical markers. Works at **language and style level**.

🔎 Proofreading

Final close reading. Get rid of any remaining errors before submission. The **smallest scope** of the three — surface-level only.

⚠️ CRITICAL DISTINCTION — THREE DIFFERENT ACTIVITIES

Revision = reorganise whole sections, change argument. **Editing** = fix sentences, grammar, word choice. **Proofreading** = fix typos and commas. They are sequential and distinct. "Moving a paragraph" = Revision. "Fixing grammar" = Editing. "Correcting spelling" = Proofreading.

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY & PLAGIARISM

⚖️ Academic Integrity

Commitment to **honesty, trust, fairness, respect, and responsibility** in all academic work. Requires properly crediting the ideas and words of others.

🚫 Plagiarism

Presenting someone else's work **without acknowledgement**. Includes: copying, close paraphrase without citation, submitting others' work, self-plagiarism.

🤖 AI Use Policy

Using AI tools without disclosure or against institutional policy is academic dishonesty. Students must follow **UB's declared AI guidelines**.

INTEGRATING SOURCES INTO WRITING

TECHNIQUE	SCOPE	CITATION REQUIRED?
🟢 **Summarising**	Condenses a **large body of text** to its main point in your own words. Macro-level — whole text → essence.	Always
🔵 **Paraphrasing**	Restates a **specific passage** in your own words, retaining the meaning. Micro-level — one passage reworded.	Always
💬 **Direct Quote**	Exact original words in quotation marks. Use sparingly — only when exact wording is critical.	Always

💡 SUMMARY VS PARAPHRASE

Summary = whole text → condensed overview

Paraphrase = one passage → reworded

The difference is **scope**: summary is macro, paraphrase is micro. Both require citations.

Reading Task also includes:

- Punctuations
- Subject-verb agreement
- Nominalisations
- Use of tenses
- In-text citations
- Hedging and boosting
- Use of personal pronouns for authority

Reporting Verbs — Stance Matters

The verb used to introduce source material signals what the author believes about the evidence.

FACTUAL / PROVEN

demonstrates · shows · proves · confirms · reveals

OPINION / ARGUABLE

argues · contends · maintains · asserts

TENTATIVE / HEDGED

suggests · proposes · indicates · implies

DOUBTED / UNVERIFIED

claims · alleges

NEUTRAL

notes · states · observes · writes

🔬 MODULE 2

Scientific Writing Style

The specific conventions that distinguish scientific writing from general academic writing. These are examinable through scenarios that test whether you can identify correct or incorrect scientific style.

ELEMENTS OF SCIENTIFIC STYLE

💡 Clear & Easy to Read

No unnecessary words or phrases. Every sentence has **one clear meaning**. Prefer short, direct constructions. Ambiguity is unacceptable in science.

✂️ Concise & Precise

Use as few words as possible without sacrificing meaning. Eliminate padding. **"Due to the fact that"** → **"because."** Word choice must be accurate and specific.

🎭 Objective & Impersonal

Avoid subjective opinions and personal/emotional references. **Restrict personal pronouns.** Focus on factual statements supported by evidence. "It was observed" not "I saw."

🔗 Logical & Coherent

Ideas flow logically and orderly. Writing that is coherent is clear and easily understood. Plan structure during prewriting to achieve this.

Language Conventions Table

CONVENTION	RULE	EXAMPLE
🚫 **Non-sexist language**	Gender-neutral terms — rewrite to plural or use "they"	"Scientists must wash **their** hands" not `his`
🌸 **Figurative language**	**Generally avoided** — metaphors can obscure precise meaning	Avoid: "the cells are a battlefield"
🕐 **Tense**	Past for Methods/Results; Present for established facts	"Water boils at 100°C" vs. "Samples were heated"
🔄 **Voice**	Passive preferred in Methods; active acceptable in Discussion	"The solution was heated" (passive)
🛡️ **Hedging**	Use cautious language — avoid absolute claims	"The results **suggest**..." / "This **may** indicate..."
🚀 **Boosting**	Strengthen claims when evidence is strong	"The data **clearly demonstrate**..." / "It is evident that..."
📚 **Correct citations**	Cite sources to provide evidence and enhance objectivity	(Ngula, 2026) / Ngula (2026) argues...

🔴 HEDGING VS BOOSTING — BOTH TESTED

Hedging = limiting certainty when evidence is incomplete: `may, might, could, suggests, appears to, tends to, approximately.`
Boosting = strengthening claims when evidence IS strong: `clearly, evidently, demonstrates, confirms, it is certain that.`
Scenarios will describe overclaiming (needs hedging) or underclaiming (needs boosting). Identify which is appropriate.

COHERENCE & COHESION

🔗 What is Coherence?

Coherence is the quality of ideas being **logically related**. Writing is coherent when the flow of ideas from beginning to end is logical, clear, and easily understood.

📌 COHERENCE LEVELS

Within a paragraph: Topic sentence → supporting sentences → concluding sentence. Each sentence links logically to the next.

Between paragraphs: Transitional sentences and logical connectors ensure the reader moves smoothly from one idea to the next.

Lack of coherence = ideas that seem random or disconnected, even if individually correct.

Cohesive Devices

DEVICE	FUNCTION	EXAMPLES
Reference Pronouns	Link back to previously mentioned nouns	it, they, this, these, such
Repetition	Repeat key terms for unity (not padding)	Repeating a central scientific concept deliberately
Logical Connectors	Show relationship between ideas	therefore, however, furthermore, consequently, in contrast
Parallelism	Similar grammatical structures for similar ideas	"The drug reduced pain, lowered inflammation, and improved mobility."

NOMINALISATION & LANGUAGE ACCURACY

🔤 Nominalisation

Converting verbs/adjectives into nouns to create a more formal, abstract style.
Verb: "We investigated..."
Nominalised: "An investigation was conducted..."
Common in formal scientific writing to **increase impersonality**.

📝 Grammar Accuracy — Key Issues

- **Subject-verb agreement** — verb must match subject in number
- **Tense and voice** — consistent and appropriate
- **Articles and prepositions** — often problematic for L2 writers
- **Incomplete sentences** — every sentence needs a main clause
- **Overlong sentences** — break up for clarity

📌 PERSONAL PRONOUNS — AUTHORITY AND PRESENCE

Scientific writing **restricts first-person pronouns** to reduce "author presence." However, in some contexts (discussion, reflexive academic writing) "we" is acceptable. The course reading task specifically lists "appropriate use of personal pronouns for authority" — meaning knowing `when` to use them and when to avoid them.

TYPES OF PARAGRAPHS / TEXTS

🔴 VERY HIGH MCQ FREQUENCY

Scenarios describe a piece of writing and ask you to name the paragraph type. Identify the **signal words** first — they almost always reveal the type immediately.

📖 Process / Descriptive `HOW IT WORKS`

Explains **how something works or is done**. Sequential steps.

`first` `then` `next` `finally` `subsequently`

🗂️ Classification `GROUPS`

Divides subject into **categories or groups** by shared traits.

`types of` `classified as` `falls into` `categorised`

⚖️ Compare & Contrast `SIMILARITIES/DIFFERENCES`

Examines **similarities and differences** between subjects.

`similarly` `in contrast` `whereas` `however` `likewise`

⚡ Cause & Effect `WHY/WHAT HAPPENS`

Explains **why** something happens and **what results**.

`because` `therefore` `as a result` `consequently` `thus`

🔧 Problem / Solution `FIX IT`

Presents a **problem and proposes solutions**.

`the problem` `one solution` `can be addressed` `recommended`

🗣️ Argumentative `TAKE A STAND`

Takes a clear **position and defends it**. Includes counter-arguments. Explicitly persuasive.

`although` `despite` `nevertheless` `it is argued`

🧩 Analytical `BREAK IT DOWN`

Breaks subject into parts; **evaluates and interprets**, not just describes. Critical thinking.

`this reveals` `examining` `indicates` `the data shows`

🪤 TRAP — ANALYTICAL VS ARGUMENTATIVE

Analytical: examines and explains — takes no explicit position. **Argumentative**: takes a side and defends it with evidence and counter-arguments. Both are critical, but argumentative is `explicitly persuasive`.

INCORPORATING GRAPHICS INTO SCIENTIFIC TEXTS

📌 Title

Every figure/table needs a descriptive title telling the reader what is shown. Must be self-sufficient.

🗝️ Legend / Key

Explains symbols, colours, abbreviations within the graphic. Should be self-contained.

🏷️ Labels

Text identifying specific parts `within` the graphic — e.g. axes of a graph, parts of a diagram.

📝 Caption

Brief explanatory description `below` the figure providing context and referring the reader to the graphic from the main text.

📄 MODULE 3

Scientific Report Writing

A **report** is a fixed-format presentation of factual information, often aimed at multiple audiences, presenting results of an investigation, trip, or research project. Reports are common in both academic and professional contexts.

TYPES OF REPORTS — THE FULL TAXONOMY

🧪 Lab Experiment Report

Documents results of a controlled laboratory experiment. Uses IMRD structure.

`Academic` `Formal`

🌍 Fieldwork Report

Documents data collected in the real world. Uses a similar IMRD structure with fieldwork methods.

`Academic` `Formal`

🚨 Incident/Accident Report

Documents unexpected harmful events. Factual, objective. Professional/institutional use.

✈️ Trip Report

Short report on a field visit, conference, or official trip. Informal — often written as email/memo.

📌 RESEARCH CONTEXT → REPORT TYPE

Library-based research → writes `scientific essays` (Introduction, Body, Conclusion). Does not collect raw data.

Fieldwork research → writes `fieldwork report` (Introduction, Methods, Results, Discussion, Conclusion, References).

Lab experiment research → writes `lab report` (Introduction, Methods, Results, Professional Informal

Professional Informal

Discussion, Conclusion). Can also include References.

🔧 Trouble Report

Documents a problem encountered — equipment failure, system error, etc. Short, factual, informal.

Professional Informal

📊 Investigative / Research Report

Long-term, multi-participant, precise format. Done for an organisation or as contractual requirement.

Academic/Professional Formal

📌 REPORT AUDIENCES

Reports may target: **Expert readers** (peers, specialists), **Non-specialists** (public, policy-makers), or **Technical readers** (engineers, lab technicians).

FORMAL VS INFORMAL REPORTS

FEATURE	Formal Reports	Informal Reports
Length	Long, multiple sections	Short — few paragraphs to a few pages
Participants	Multiple participants, long-term	Usually one writer, short-term task
Structure	Precise, defined format (e.g., IMRD)	Introduction, body, conclusion ± recommendations
Purpose/Context	Done for own organisation or contractual requirement for another entity	Often written as correspondences — letters, memos, emails
Examples	Research reports, investigative reports, lab experiment reports	Trip reports, trouble reports, accident reports
Tone	Highly formal, technical	Formal but more conversational; concise

LAB REPORTS — IMRD STRUCTURE

Lab experiments begin with an **observation → question → hypothesis**, which is then investigated as an experiment. The write-up follows IMRD.

I

Introduction / Background

Background context, research question, hypothesis, and objective. Why was the experiment conducted?

Present + Past tense · Mixed voice

M

Methods

Exactly what was done so others can replicate. Experiment design, materials, analysis procedure.

Past tense · PASSIVE voice

R

Results

Data and observations only — no interpretation whatsoever. Tables, graphs, figures with captions.

Past tense · No opinion

D

Discussion

Interprets results, compares to hypothesis and literature, explains errors, draws conclusions.

Mixed tense · Hedging

🔴 CRITICAL DISTINCTION — RESULTS VS DISCUSSION

Results = what happened (data, observations — zero interpretation). **Discussion** = what it means (interpretation, explanation, conclusions, limitations). A student interpreting data in the Results section = always a **structural error**.

Additional Lab Report Components

COMPONENT	PLACEMENT	PURPOSE
🔵 **Abstract**	Before Introduction (written last)	150–250 word summary — purpose, method, key results, conclusion. Written after the report is complete.
📌 **Title**	Top of report	Specific and informative — names the variables. Not "Experiment 1."
📚 **References**	End of report	Full bibliography of all cited sources in correct format (usually APA).
📎 **Appendices**	After references	Raw data, additional calculations — material too detailed for main text.

FIELDWORK REPORTS

Fieldwork involves going into the **real world** to gather data on a topic and analyse it to derive new information. Unlike lab reports, variables are not controlled — the researcher works in natural conditions.

Fieldwork Report Structure

SECTION	CONTENT
Introduction / Background	Context, research question, objectives of the fieldwork
Methods	Research design, data collection methods (surveys, interviews, observation), analysis procedure

🔬 LAB VS FIELDWORK

Lab experiment: controlled setting, variables can be manipulated, indoors.

Fieldwork: real-world setting, less control, outdoors or in natural context.

Both result in a similar IMRD-type report structure. The key difference is the `context and control`, not the format.

SECTION	CONTENT
Results	Findings from the fieldwork — what data was collected
Discussion	Interpretation, patterns, comparison with literature
Conclusion	Key takeaways, recommendations
References	All cited sources in APA format

Note: some experiments can be done on the field — they are still lab-type in their approach.

ACCIDENT / INCIDENT REPORTS

🔴 TRIGGER = UNPLANNED HARMFUL EVENT

Accident reports are not about research. They document **unexpected harmful events** in labs, workplaces, or field settings. Serves legal, safety, insurance, and preventive functions.

Core Features

FEATURE	WHAT IT MEANS
🎯 **Accuracy**	Exact times, dates, locations, names. No rounding or omissions.
💡 **Clarity**	Plain, unambiguous language. Non-experts (lawyers, insurers) must understand it.
⚖️ **Objectivity**	**No speculation, blame, or opinion.** Only report what was observed or known.
📋 **Completeness**	Who, what, when, where, how, and what immediate action was taken.
⏰ **Timeliness**	Completed as soon as possible while memory is fresh.

⚠ LANGUAGE RULES

- **Past tense** throughout — events have already occurred
- **Passive or impersonal constructions** for objectivity
- **No emotive language** — factual tone only
- **Specific details** — exact measurements, timestamps
- Short, direct sentences

Wrong: "Kefilwe was being reckless."

Right: "The flask was dropped, resulting in a spill on the laboratory floor."

Structure of an Accident Report

SECTION	CONTENT
Header / Identification	Date, time, location, report number, organisation name
Persons Involved	Names, roles, contact details, witnesses
Description of Incident	Factual, chronological account — the core narrative
Cause Analysis	Immediate and root causes — objectively stated, no blame
Injuries / Damage	Nature and extent of injuries or damage to property/equipment
Immediate Action Taken	First aid given, emergency services called, area secured
Recommendations	Proposed measures to prevent recurrence
Signatures	Reporter, supervisor, witnesses — authenticates the report

TRIP REPORTS & TROUBLE REPORTS

✈️ Trip Report

Documents a **field visit, conference attendance, or official travel**. Typically informal — can be conveyed as an email, memo, or letter.

Typical structure: Purpose of trip → Activities/events attended → Findings or outcomes → Recommendations (if any)

Audience: Supervisor or organisation. **Tone:** Formal but concise.

🔧 Trouble Report

Documents a **problem encountered** — equipment failure, system malfunction, process breakdown. Short and factual.

Typical structure: Problem description → Impact/consequences → Steps taken → Recommended fix

Audience: Supervisor, IT/maintenance team, management. Often informal — email or memo format.

💡 CONTEXT FOR PROFESSIONAL REPORTS AT UB

Trip and trouble reports are **professional reports**, not academic ones. They are discussed in the context of professional writing. Most are informal and can be conveyed through emails, memos, or letters. You may be required to write them as a science student on field placements or internships.

COMPARING ALL REPORT TYPES

FEATURE	🧪 Lab Report	🌍 Fieldwork Report	🚨 Accident Report	✈️ Trip/Trouble
Trigger	Controlled experiment	Real-world data collection	Unplanned harmful event	Trip / problem / breakdown
Academic or Professional?	Academic	Academic	Professional	Professional
Formal or Informal?	Formal	Formal	Informal	Informal
Structure	IMRD	IMRD-like + References	Who/What/When + Action	Short prose or memo format
Contains hypothesis?	Yes	Sometimes	No	No
Contains interpretation?	Yes (Discussion)	Yes (Discussion)	Limited	Limited
Objective/neutral?	Yes	Yes	Strictly required	Yes
Contains blame?	Never	Never	Never	Never

📚 MODULE 4 · NEW FREQUENTLY TESTED

APA Citation Style — Complete Guide

The **American Psychological Association (APA 7th edition)** style is widely used in science, social science, and academic writing at UB. Citations appear in **two places**: in-text (within the writing) and in the reference list (at the end). Both must be correct.

APA STYLE — THE BASICS

📐 Why We Cite — The Principles

- To give credit to the original author's ideas — **intellectual honesty**
- To allow readers to locate and verify your sources
- To provide **evidence** for your claims and strengthen objectivity
- To demonstrate engagement with the literature
- To avoid **plagiarism**

🔴 TWO-PART SYSTEM — BOTH REQUIRED

Every source cited in text MUST appear in the reference list. Every source in the reference list MUST be cited in text. Mismatch = academic error.

📌 APA 7TH EDITION KEY CHANGES

- **Up to 20 authors** listed in reference (previously 6)
- **Running head** no longer required for student papers
- **DOI presented as hyperlink**: https://doi.org/xxxxx
- **Publisher location** no longer required for books
- "**Retrieved from**" only needed if content changes over time
- Use **singular "they"** as gender-neutral pronoun

⚠️ MOST COMMON APA MISTAKES

1) Missing comma between author and year. 2) Wrong punctuation around page number. 3) Italicising wrong elements. 4) Missing DOI or URL. 5) Reference list not in alphabetical order.

APA Core Author-Date Formula

IN-TEXT FORMAT

```
(Author's Last Name, Year)
```

✓ (Ngula, 2026) | Ngula (2026) argues… | (Aliotta, 2018, p. 45)

REFERENCE LIST GENERAL FORMULA

Author, A. A. (Year). *Title of work.* Publisher/Source.

IN-TEXT CITATIONS — ALL SCENARIOS

One Author

PARENTHETICAL (AUTHOR IN BRACKETS)

✓ Climate change is accelerating (Ngula, 2026).

✗ Climate change is accelerating (Ngula 2026).

NARRATIVE (AUTHOR'S NAME IN SENTENCE)

✓ Ngula (2026) argues that climate change is accelerating.

Missing comma between author and year

× Ngula (2026) argues that climate change is accelerating (Ngula, 2026).

Don't double-cite in the same sentence

Two Authors

ALWAYS NAME BOTH AUTHORS EVERY TIME — USE "&" IN BRACKETS, "AND" IN NARRATIVE

✓ (Ngula & Aliotta, 2026) | Ngula and Aliotta (2026) found that…

× (Ngula & Aliotta, 2026) | Ngula & Aliotta (2026) found that…

In narrative text: use "and" not "&"

Three or More Authors

USE "ET AL." FROM THE FIRST CITATION (APA 7TH ED.)

✓ (Ngula et al., 2026) | Ngula et al. (2026) suggest…

× (Ngula, Aliotta, Bailey, & Langan, 2026)

APA 7th: use et al. from the very first citation (3+ authors)

Direct Quotation — With Page Number

PAGE NUMBER REQUIRED FOR DIRECT QUOTES — USE P. (ONE PAGE) OR PP. (RANGE)

✓ "Scientific writing must be clear, concise, and precise" (Ngula, 2026, p. 14).

✓ Ngula (2026) states that "scientific writing must be clear, concise, and precise" (p. 14).

× "Scientific writing must be clear, concise, and precise" (Ngula, 2026).

Missing page number for direct quote

No Author

USE THE FIRST FEW WORDS OF THE TITLE (IN ITALICS FOR WORKS; IN "QUOTES" FOR ARTICLES/WEB PAGES)

✓ (*Academic Writing Guide*, 2024) | ("Writing for Science," 2024)

No Date

USE N.D. (NO DATE)

✓ (University of Botswana, n.d.) | University of Botswana (n.d.) states…

Organisation / Institution as Author

SPELL OUT IN FULL ON FIRST USE; ABBREVIATE IN SUBSEQUENT CITATIONS IF WELL KNOWN

✓ First use: (World Health Organization [WHO], 2023) | Subsequent: (WHO, 2023)

Multiple Sources in One Citation

SEPARATE WITH SEMICOLONS; LIST ALPHABETICALLY

✓ (Aliotta, 2018; Bailey, 2015; Ngula, 2026)

× (Ngula, 2026; Bailey, 2015; Aliotta, 2018)

Must be alphabetical order

Secondary Source (Citing a Source Cited by Another)

USE "AS CITED IN" — ONLY THE SECONDARY SOURCE GOES IN YOUR REFERENCE LIST

✓ Bailey (2001, as cited in Ngula, 2026) found that… | (Bailey, 2001, as cited in Ngula, 2026)

Bailey does NOT appear in your reference list — Ngula (2026) does

REFERENCE LIST — SOURCE TYPE FORMATS

📌 REFERENCE LIST RULES

(1) Start on a new page titled "References" (centred, bold). **(2)** Alphabetical by first author's last name. **(3)** Hanging indent (second line indented). **(4)** Double-spaced. **(5)** Italicise titles of books and journals (not article titles).

📖 Book (Single Author)

FORMAT

Author, A. A. (Year). *Title of book: Subtitle if any.* Publisher.

✓ Langan, J. (2011). *College writing skills with readings* (8th ed.). McGraw-Hill.

× Langan, J. (2011). College Writing Skills With Readings (8th ed.). McGraw-Hill.

Book title: sentence case + italics. Not title case.

📖 Book (Multiple Authors)

LIST ALL AUTHORS (UP TO 20) USING "&" BEFORE LAST AUTHOR

✓ Aliotta, M., & Bailey, S. (2018). *Academic writing for science students.* Oxford University Press.

📖 Book with Edition

✓ Bottomley, J. (2022). *Academic writing for international students of science* (2nd ed.). Routledge.

📰 Journal Article

FORMAT

Author, A. A. (Year). Title of article. *Name of Journal, Volume*(Issue), pages. https://doi.org/xxxxx

✓ Ngula, R. (2026). Scientific writing in Botswana universities. *Journal of Academic Writing, 12*(3), 45-62. https://doi.org/10.1000/xyz123

× Ngula, R. (2026). Scientific writing in Botswana universities. *Journal of Academic Writing, 12*(3), 45-62.

Journal name AND volume both italicised. DOI required when available.

🌐 Website / Webpage

FORMAT

Author, A. A. (Year, Month Day). *Title of page.* Website Name. URL

✓ University of Botswana. (2024, March 15). *Academic integrity policy.* University of Botswana. https://www.ub.bw/integrity

× University of Botswana. (2024). Academic Integrity Policy. Retrieved from https://www.ub.bw/integrity

"Retrieved from" not needed if content is static. Title in sentence case + italics.

📄 Chapter in an Edited Book

FORMAT — NOTE: CHAPTER AUTHOR FIRST, THEN EDITOR(S)

Author, A. A. (Year). Title of chapter. In E. E. Editor (Ed.), *Title of book* (pp. xx-xx). Publisher.

✓ Bailey, S. (2015). Structuring scientific essays. In R. Ngula (Ed.), *Academic writing in Africa* (pp. 23-45). UB Press.

📊 Report / Grey Literature

FORMAT — GOVERNMENT REPORTS, INSTITUTIONAL REPORTS

Author, A. A. (Year). *Title of report.* Organisation. URL

✓ World Health Organization. (2023). *Global status report on air pollution.* WHO. https://www.who.int/reports/air

APA CITATION — SCENARIO-BASED PRACTICE

APA SCENARIO

APA-01 · In-Text Format

READ THE SITUATION

A student paraphrases an idea from a book written by Dr. Ngula published in 2026. She writes: "Scientific writing must adhere to formal conventions Ngula, 2026." What is wrong with this citation and how should it be corrected?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

Missing parentheses — citation not enclosed in brackets

EXPLANATION

The in-text citation must be enclosed in parentheses: **(Ngula, 2026)**. The corrected sentence: "Scientific writing must adhere to formal conventions **(Ngula, 2026)**." Additionally, there should be a comma between the author's name and the year, which is present here but would be another common error to watch for.

APA SCENARIO

APA-02 · Three Authors

READ THE SITUATION

A research paper has three authors: Ngula, Aliotta, and Bailey. It was published in 2024. A student cites it for the first time in his essay as: "(Ngula, Aliotta, & Bailey, 2024)". Is this correct under APA 7th edition?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

No — APA 7th ed. requires "et al." from the first citation for 3+ authors

EXPLANATION

Under **APA 7th edition**, when a work has **3 or more authors**, you use "et al." from the `very first citation`. Correct format: **(Ngula et al., 2024)**. The format "(Ngula, Aliotta, & Bailey, 2024)" was correct under APA 6th edition but is now incorrect. This is a high-frequency MCQ distinction.

APA SCENARIO

APA-03 · Direct Quote

READ THE SITUATION

A student copies this sentence word-for-word from page 22 of Langan's (2011) textbook: "Every paragraph should have a topic sentence that states the main idea." She cites it as: "Every paragraph should have a topic sentence that states the main idea" (Langan, 2011). What is missing?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

Missing page number — required for all direct quotes

EXPLANATION

For **direct quotations**, APA requires a **page number** in the in-text citation. Correct format: **(Langan, 2011, p. 22)**. The full corrected sentence: "Every paragraph should have a topic sentence that states the main idea" **(Langan, 2011, p. 22)**. Page numbers are mandatory for quotes but optional for paraphrases (though recommended).

APA SCENARIO

APA-04 · Reference List Format

READ THE SITUATION

A student writes this reference entry for a journal article: "Ngula, R. (2026). Scientific Writing in Botswana. Journal of Academic Writing, 12, 45–62." Identify all errors in this reference entry.

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

Three errors: title case, missing volume italics, missing issue number & DOI

EXPLANATION

Error 1: Article title should be in `sentence case`, not title case: "Scientific writing in Botswana." **Error 2:** The journal name AND volume number should both be italicised: `Journal of Academic Writing, 12`. **Error 3:** Issue number is missing (should be in brackets after volume, not italicised): `12`(3). **Error 4:** DOI or URL should be included if available. **Correct entry:** Ngula, R. (2026). Scientific writing in Botswana. `Journal of Academic Writing, 12`(3), 45–62. https://doi.org/xxxxx

APA SCENARIO

APA-05 · Secondary Source

READ THE SITUATION

A student wants to cite a theory by Swales (1990) but only has access to Ngula's (2026) book which discusses Swales' work. The student writes: "(Swales, 1990, as cited in Ngula, 2026)". Which source appears in the reference list?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

Only Ngula (2026) goes in the reference list — not Swales (1990)

EXPLANATION

When using a **secondary source**, the source you actually read goes in your reference list. The student read **Ngula (2026)**, so that is the entry in the reference list. Swales (1990) is not included because the student did not directly access that source. The in-text citation "(Swales, 1990, as cited in Ngula, 2026)" is correct. Use secondary sources sparingly — try to locate the original source when possible.

APA SCENARIO

APA-06 · Paraphrase vs Quote Citation

READ THE SITUATION

A student reads Chapter 3 of Bottomley (2022) and writes a sentence summarising the chapter's main argument in her own words. She includes "(Bottomley, 2022)" at the end. Another student copies two sentences verbatim from page 87 and cites them as "(Bottomley, 2022)". Which student has cited correctly?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

Student 1 is correct. Student 2 is missing the page number and quotation marks.

EXPLANATION

Student 1 (paraphrase/summary): "(Bottomley, 2022)" is correct. Page numbers are recommended but not required for paraphrases. **Student 2** (direct quote): Has two errors. (1) The copied text must appear in **quotation marks** to signal it is a direct quote. (2) The citation must include the **page number**: (Bottomley, 2022, p. 87). Without quotation marks, Student 2 has committed **plagiarism** even with the citation, because readers cannot tell which words are the author's original language.

🎯 INTEGRATED EXAM PRACTICE

Scenario Practice Bank — All Modules

Scenario questions spanning all four modules. Attempt each before revealing the answer.

SCENARIO QUESTION

01 · Stage Identification

READ THE SITUATION

Kabo is about to write a lab report. Before writing a single sentence, he draws a web diagram connecting "photosynthesis" to related concepts like "light," "chlorophyll," and "glucose." What strategy is Kabo using and in which stage?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

Mind/Concept Map — Prewriting Stage (Stage 1)

EXPLANATION

Visually connecting ideas before writing any draft = brainstorming using a mind/concept map. This is a core **Prewriting** activity. Key signal: no draft sentences have been written yet.

SCENARIO QUESTION

02 · Post-Writing Stages

READ THE SITUATION

After peer feedback, Thato moves her third paragraph to become the introduction. She then fixes an awkward sentence. Finally she corrects three spelling errors. Name all three activities.

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

Revision → Editing → Proofreading

EXPLANATION

Revision: restructuring organisation (macro). **Editing**: fixing an awkward sentence (sentence-level). **Proofreading**: correcting spelling (surface). Sequential and distinct.

SCENARIO QUESTION

03 · Report Type Selection

READ THE SITUATION

Scenario A: A biology student measures the effect of pH on enzyme activity over five controlled trials and uses IMRD structure. Scenario B: A lab assistant slips on a wet floor and fractures their wrist — the supervisor records the incident. Scenario C: A lecturer attends a conference in Gaborone and writes a brief account of what was presented. Which report type applies to each?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

A = Lab Report (IMRD) | B = Accident Report | C = Trip Report

EXPLANATION

A = Lab Report — planned controlled experiment, IMRD structure, academic and formal. **B** = Accident Report — unplanned harmful event, factual documentation, professional and informal. **C** = Trip Report — account of official travel/event attendance, professional and informal, often written as a memo or email.

SCENARIO QUESTION

04 · Paragraph Type

READ THE SITUATION

"Increased CO_2 emissions are leading to higher global temperatures. As a result, polar ice caps are melting, which consequently causes rising sea levels." What paragraph type is this?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

Cause and Effect

EXPLANATION

Chain of causation + signal words: "leading to," "as a result," "consequently." These are definitive cause-and-effect markers.

SCENARIO QUESTION

05 · IMRD Section

READ THE SITUATION

"The results suggest that increased temperature may have caused higher enzyme activity, possibly because heat provides additional kinetic energy." In which IMRD section does this belong?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

Discussion section

EXPLANATION

The sentence **interprets** ("the results suggest") and offers a **scientific explanation** ("possibly because heat provides kinetic energy"). Both belong in Discussion. If placed in Results, it would be a structural error.

SCENARIO QUESTION

06 · Hedging vs Boosting

READ THE SITUATION

Student A writes: "This experiment definitively proves that the drug cures cancer." Student B writes: "The evidence weakly suggests there might possibly be some slight effect." Both are marked down. What is wrong with each?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

A = Over-boosting (lacks hedging). B = Over-hedging (too cautious, unclear).

EXPLANATION

Student A: "Definitively proves" and "cures" are absolute claims — inappropriate in science. Needs hedging: "The results `suggest` the drug `may` reduce cancer cell growth." **Student B**: Stacked hedges ("weakly suggests," "might possibly," "slight effect") create vagueness that obscures meaning. Scientific writing requires `appropriate` hedging — not excessive. Balance certainty with the strength of your evidence.

SCENARIO QUESTION

07 · Formal vs Informal Report

READ THE SITUATION

A government environmental scientist is commissioned to investigate water quality across 12 sites over 18 months, involving a team of 5 researchers. Which type of report will they produce, and why?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

Formal investigative/research report

EXPLANATION

The markers of a **formal report** are all present: long-term (18 months), multiple participants (5 researchers), commissioned (done for an organisation as a contractual requirement), and requires precise format. Formal reports include research reports and investigative reports.

APA + INTEGRITY SCENARIO

08 · Citation & Plagiarism

READ THE SITUATION

Neo changes three words in a paragraph from a journal article and does not include a citation. He then adds a citation at the end of his essay in the reference list. Has he cited correctly? Has he plagiarised?

▲ Hide Answer

✅ CORRECT ANSWER

No — not cited correctly. Yes — he has plagiarised.

EXPLANATION

Two problems: **(1) Citation error** — a source in the reference list without an in-text citation is an incomplete citation. Readers cannot identify which idea belongs to which source. Every paraphrase/quote needs both an in-text citation AND a reference list entry. **(2) Plagiarism** — changing only 3 words does not constitute genuine paraphrasing. True paraphrasing requires a complete restatement of the idea in your own words, with a different structure. Even with a citation, superficial word substitution is academically dishonest.

⚡ MASTER QUICK REFERENCE

Complete Cheat Sheet — All Modules

Last-minute scan cards. Know these cold and you'll navigate every scenario question with confidence.

📝 Writing Stage Decision

Mind maps, outlines, keyword search, audience & purpose analysis	Stage 1 · Prewriting
Drafting intro/body/conclusion, citing sources, writing paragraphs	Stage 2 · Writing
Restructuring sections, changing arguments, moving paragraphs	Revision
Fixing sentences, grammar, word choice, transitions	Editing
Correcting typos, spelling, punctuation	Proofreading

📄 Report Type Decision

Planned, controlled experiment → IMRD	Lab Report
Real-world data collection → IMRD-like	Fieldwork Report
Unplanned harmful event → formal record	Accident Report
Official trip/conference → short account	Trip Report
Equipment/system failure → document problem	Trouble Report
Long-term, multi-participant, commissioned	Formal/Research Report

🧩 Paragraph Type Signal Words

first / then / next / finally / subsequently	Process / Descriptive
types of / classified as / falls into	Classification
similarly / in contrast / whereas / however	Compare & Contrast
because / therefore / as a result / consequently	Cause & Effect
the problem / one solution / recommended	Problem / Solution
it is argued / although / nevertheless	Argumentative
this reveals / examining / the data shows	Analytical

🧪 IMRD Language Rules

Introduction	Present (facts) + Past (prior work). Mixed voice.
Methods	**Past tense · Passive voice.** "...was added..."
Results	Past tense. Passive. **No interpretation.**
Discussion	Mixed tense. **Hedging language essential.**
Abstract	Written last, placed first. 150–250 words.

📚 APA In-Text — Quick Rules

1 author	(Ngula, 2026)
2 authors	(Ngula & Aliotta, 2026)
3+ authors	(Ngula et al., 2026) — from 1st cite
Direct quote	(Ngula, 2026, p. 22) — page required
No author	(*Shortened Title*, Year)
No date	(Ngula, n.d.)
Secondary source	(Swales, 1990, as cited in Ngula, 2026)

📚 APA Reference List — Key Formats

Book	Author. (Year). *Title.* Publisher.
Journal article	Author. (Year). Title. *Journal, Vol*(Iss), pp. DOI
Website	Author. (Year). *Title.* Site Name. URL
Book chapter	Author. (Year). Chapter. In Ed. (Ed.), *Book* (pp.). Publisher.
What is italicised?	Book titles, journal names + volume numbers
Title case?	Sentence case for articles/books. Title case for journals.

✅ **Final Exam Tip:** For every scenario, pause and ask: **(1) What is the person doing?** and **(2) What type of text are they producing?** These two questions will eliminate wrong answers and guide you to the correct one. For APA scenarios, identify the **source type** and the **number of authors** first.